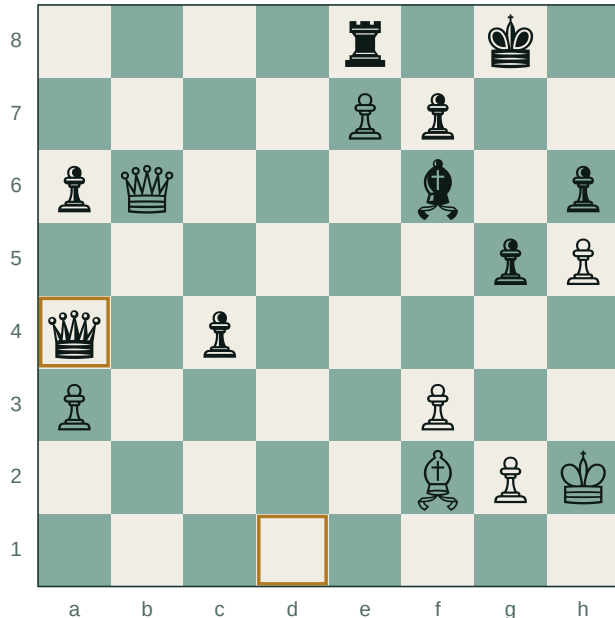


Loose-piece tactics: White, move 32

Loose-piece tactics

White to move



Previous move: 31...Qa4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

32. Qxf6 c3 33. Bd4 Qxd4 34. Qxd4

32.Qxf6 The queen captures the bishop on f6. Recorded reply: **32...c3**.

33.Bd4 The bishop moves from f2 to d4. Recorded reply: **33...Qxd4**.

34.Qxd4 The queen captures the queen on d4.

At the end, nominal material is White 14 / Black 10 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +9. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +9: the balance goes from -5 to +4. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on g8. Geometrically undefended: bishop on f6 and queen on a4. Check for tactical protection.